

FICTION LINKS FOR SENIOR ENGLISH STUDENTS

Critical works and support

Online

The ANZ Reference Centre database can be very useful for finding reviews and critical works published in newspaper and magazines.

In addition, there are a number of Internet sites that provide guides and critical information on works of literature that you may find a useful support to your independent reading:

[AustLit -The Australian Literature Resource](#)

[Spark Notes](#)

[Bookrags](#)

[Study Guides for literature](#). Useful guides for a limited range of titles.

[Vintage Guides](#) These guides are designed as discussion starters for book groups but may provide some stimulating ideas for your consideration and understanding of your reading.

[Classic Notes by Gradesaver](#) Critical notes and essays on a large range of "classic" novels, including "modern classics".

[Good Books Lately](#) Brief descriptions and reviews. Thematic lists of recommended titles may be helpful in selection. United States based site with an emphasis on American works.

[Novelguide.com](#). Worth navigating past the many ads on this site to get to useful notes on a number of frequently studied novels.

[Picador notes for reading groups](#) Useful notes on a number of Australian fiction books, including Tim Winton's *The Riders* and *Dirt Music*.

Also check the links on the Resource Centre Reviews page. Links on the [Public Libraries](#) site may be particularly useful.

Resource Centre

The Resource Centre has developed an extensive collection of books that are of a suitable literary quality to be considered for the independent reading component of English Studies. This collection is shelved in the Extension, (yellow dot) area of the Fiction section.

Remember that Fiction can be searched on the library catalogue not only by author and title, but also by subject. Use the Advanced Search option to select part of the fiction collection, (e.g. Library - Extension

Reading), then enter a subject, (e.g. family, war, immigration, or more specific subjects). Books in the Extension collection can easily be identified on the Webopac by **EXT** following the call number.

In addition the Resource Centre holds an extensive range of support material for Extension fiction books. This material can also be located by searching the Catalogue. A comprehensive search of resources can be conducted by entering the author's name in the search field.

Note that many of these books are held behind the circulation desk; location can be verified by checking the book's *Collection* details.

Most importantly, remember if you're having trouble locating material, ask one of the library staff.

INDIVIDUAL STUDY (INDEPENDENT READING)

The lists linked to this page are intended to provide ideas and inspiration for your reading. They may provide a starting point when contemplating paired texts and critical essays.

The Thematic index does not yet include the entire collection. The entire collection can however be searched by theme via the Webopac. All fiction books are catalogued with subject, (theme) headings. You can do a subject search by using a theme word and *fiction*, e.g. *racism fiction* will locate all fiction books with the theme of racism - books suitable for PES studies can then be identified by the EXT that appears after the call number.

Don't hesitate to ask Resource Centre staff if you require assistance.

Always confirm your selection with your English teacher.

[Thematic index to fiction for senior English students](#)

[Fiction prize winners](#)

Particularly notable prizes are the Nobel prize for literature, the Booker prize, The Pulitzer prize, and for Australian fiction, The Miles Franklin award.

TEXT SELECTION AND CRITICAL ESSAY QUESTION EXAMPLES

Most of the following examples were provided in a paper presented by Paul Kilvert, the chief examiner of English Studies, at an English Studies conference in 1997. The purpose of the examples is not only to give examples of text selection based on thematic links, but also to illustrate how issues may be incorporated into an effective topic.

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To what extent do the women in your reading conquer their fate?

Alice Walker	The color purple
Lynne Reid Banks	The L-shaped room
Amy Tan	The kitchen God's wife

"I am ready for whatever comes next." To what extent do the authors allow the expression of freedom in their central female characters?

Thomas Hardy	Tess of the D'Urbervilles
Miles Franklin	My brilliant career
Kate Grenville	Lilian's story

In what ways has living in a foreign country affected the characters' lives and moulded them as people?

Gabrielle Carey	In my father's house
Thea Astley	Reaching Tin river
Jessica Anderson	Tirra Lirra by the river

Literature often exposes the nature of female repression within all societies at all times. From the texts studied this year, what have you discovered about the nature of female repression?

Jane Austen	Pride and prejudice
Jannette Turner Hospital	The ivory swing
Margaret Atwood	The handmaid's tale

Both Jane Austen and Elizabeth Jolly show the roles and choices of women in their time. Discuss how the two authors' interpretations of women differ.

Jane Austen	Pride and prejudice
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Jane Austen	Emma
Elizabeth Jolly	The well

In your reading how did the writers use the story of their main characters' childhoods to present their concerns?

Harper Lee	To kill a mockingbird
J.G. Ballard	Empire of the sun
Tim Winton	That eye, the sky

The english patient, The ghost road and Highways to a war all show how different people and places are affected as a result of the atrocities of war. In relation to these three novels, show how war has affected the individual, the community and the country.

Pat Barker	The ghost road
Michael Ondaatje	The english patient
Christopher Koch	Highways to a war

Writers use a variety of methods to criticise aspects of society, including satire, humour and anger.

Joseph Heller	Catch 22
Peter Goldsworthy	Wish

Good science fiction challenges the way we see individuals and society. In exploring imaginary worlds, we explore our own.

Ursula Le Guin	The left hand of darkness
Margaret Atwood	The handmaid's tale
Aldous Huxley	Brave new world

Authors show us constructions of future worlds in which we are able to see accurately the directions in which our society might be headed. How true is this and what kinds of warnings do they seem to be offering?

Aldous Huxley	Brave new world
Anthony Burgess	A clockwork orange
Andre Zamyatin	We

Many authors choose not to write about what could be described as 'realistic' novels, but through unusual settings, differently perceived characters and unconventional narrative techniques challenge the reader's views of the world and what is real? How far is this true of the novels you have read?

Gabriel Garcia Marquez	One hundred years of solitude
Haruki Murakami	Dance, dance, dance
David Malouf	An imaginary life
William Wharton	Birdy

In the three texts you studied, to what extent did the authors show human nature to be hollow at the core?

Joseph Conrad	Heart of darkness
Alexander Solzhenitsyn	One day in the life of Ivan Denisovich
David Malouf	Fly away Peter

Colonisation has a profound effect on the indigenous cultures of the colony. To what extent have you found this to be true in your reading?

Paul Scott	Staying on
Ruth Praver Jhabvala	Heat and dust

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Joyce Cary	Mister Johnson
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Human tolerance is to allow and permit individual differences in others. How have the authors you studied this year examined the issue of racial tolerance?

Nadine Gordimer	
Alan Paton	
John Briley	Cry freedom

Are conformity, stability and happiness more desirable than individuality, freedom and truth?

George Orwell	1984
Aldous Huxley	Brave new world
Albert Camus	The outsider

Those deemed insane by society are all too often victims of a system which insists on conformity.

Albertus Camus	The outsider
Ken Kesey	One flew over the cuckoo's nest
Charlotte Perkins Gilman	The yellow wallpaper

Truly great writers don't just tell good stories. They challenge philosophical beliefs. They confront their readers. They teach with passion.

Nathaniel Hawthorne	The scarlet letter
Helen Gardner	The first stone
Voltaire	Candide

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A significant feature of the *The English Patient*, *The Riders* and *Beirut Blues* is the author's portrayal of the way people's lives are shaped by their spiritual and physical environment. Discuss.

Michael Ondaatje	<i>The English Patient</i>
Tim Winton	<i>The Riders</i>
Hanan al-Shaykh	<i>Beirut Blues</i>

Writers are often inspired by injustice in society and their works include their opinions of what are the causes and possible solutions to the injustice. How is this true of the authors you studied for your folio?

Alan Paton	<i>Cry, the Beloved Country</i>
Nadine Gordimer	<i>Jury's People</i>

Literature often depicts the struggle of people against the forces of evil. Sometimes they triumph over these forces, sometimes they succumb. How have the characters in the novels you studied this year triumphed and succumbed?

Oscar Wilde	<i>The Picture of Dorian Gray</i>
Robert Louis Stevenson	<i>The Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde</i>
Joseph Conrad	<i>The Heart of Darkness</i>

Literature frequently depicts men and women struggling against forces more powerful than them. Sometimes they triumph over these forces, sometimes they succumb to them. To what extent have the characters in your reading triumphed or succumbed?

Ida Fink	<i>The Journey</i>
Mario Vargas Llosa	<i>The Feast of the Goat</i>
Thomas Keneally	<i>Schindler's Ark</i>

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How do the authors in the three texts you have read use characters and writing techniques to express their ideas? How are these ideas similar and different?

Ken Kesey	One flew over the cuckoo's nest
Andre Brink	A dry white season
Alexander Solzhenitsyn	One day in the life of Ivan Denisovich

Music is a consummate means of defining the roles, functions and the power of individual characters. Discuss in relation to your reading this year.

Peter Goldsworthy	Maestro
Peter Ackroyd	English music
Helen Garner	The children's Bach
Vikram Seth	An equal music

It is easy to envisage central characters as being evil. It is harder to envisage them as the victim, trapped in situations from which they are unable to extricate themselves. Discuss this statement with close reference to your reading.

Graham Greene	Brighton rock
Anthony Burgess	A clockwork orange
Fyodor Dostoevsky	Crime and punishment
Mario Vargas Llosa	The feast of the goat

Cultural Expectations may vary, but the process of discovering self-identity is an universal experience. To what extent is this true of the lives of characters in the texts that you have studied?

Gabrielle Carey	In my father's house
Mark Behr	The smell of apples

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Colm Toibin	The south
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Faced with extreme hardship, humans often look towards a transcendent reality for support and comfort. Discuss this statement with references to your reading.

Alexander Solzhenitsyn	One day in the life of Ivan Denisovich
R. K. Narayan	The guide
Chinua Achebe	Things fall apart

In their struggle to determine their own identity individuals need to resist the pressure to conform to society's expectations. To what extent is this true of the main characters in Remembering Babylon and Heat and dust?

David Malouf	Remembering Babylon
Ruth Praver Jhabvala	Heat and dust
Tim Winton	The riders
Albert Camus	The outsider